

consensus mechanisms being developed, such as proof-of-stake, proof-of-existence, proof-of-elapsed-time, and so on. Just as machine learning is not just one thing, but composed of the Symbolists, Connectionists, Evolutionaries, Bayesians, and Analogizers, so too can blockchain technology have many flavors. In *The Master Algorithm*,⁷ Pedro Domingos hypothesizes that all these camps of machine learning—which at times have been bitter rivals—will one day coalesce. The same will likely be true of blockchain technology. If these distributed databases of value are to be truly transformational, they will have to interoperate and value one another.

THE MANY USES OF THE WORD *BLOCKCHAIN*

Despite increased interest in blockchain technology, confusion remains as to what it specifically means due to imprecision in the use of the term. For example, “a blockchain,” “the blockchain,” “blockchain,” and “blockchain technology” can all refer to different things.

Typically, when people say *the blockchain*, they are referring to *the original*, or Bitcoin’s blockchain. At the risk of redundancy but in pursuit of clarity, we will always use “Bitcoin’s blockchain” instead of “the blockchain.”

On the other hand, terms such as *a blockchain* and *blockchain technology* typically refer to derivatives of the original that now may have nothing to do with Bitcoin. Meanwhile, *blockchain* is normally used to refer to the concept itself, with no particular implementation in mind. It is the most amorphous, so our least favored of the terms.